

5.2 Slackware

Slackware is one of those distributions that is notorious for being difficult to work with. Slackware is generally recommended for Linux enthusiasts who want to start learning the toughest aspects of Linux. While it is true that you have to compile most packages from source, Slackware 12.2 comes with audio players, codecs and a range of applications. After the installation, you can play an MP3 file right away, which is more than what an easy distro, “Linux for human beings”, Ubuntu allows for. Slackware is one of the earliest distros of Linux to come about, and is the oldest distro still in active development. The development is done by an individual known as Patrick Volkerding, and as such the timeline is leisurely, with even the latest versions having slightly outdated software.

As Debian is preferred for its comprehensive repositories for derivative distributions, similarly, Slackware is popular because of its simplicity and reliability. Simplicity here should be read as a basic, solid and uncluttered installation, instead of ease of use. The design philosophy of Slackware is heavily inspired by the KISS principle, which stands for Keep It Simple, Stupid. Slackware is as close as any modern Linux based operating system gets to a UNIX operating system. Vector Linux, Zenwalk and Wolvix Cub are some of the more common Linux distros based on Slackware.

5.2.1 Installing Slackware

Slackware 12.0 does not have a graphical user interface for installation, but that is nothing to be afraid of. Although the installation is all in text, every step of the installation is very clearly described by Slackware, and it is not inherently more difficult than a GUI installation, perhaps simply less familiar. If you are planning to dual boot slackware, it is advisable to create about 10 GB or more of unformatted disk space using **cmd>diskmgmt** on your Windows installation. Expanding and contracting partitions is not easy during the Slackware installation, unless you use a tool such as GParted before installing Slackware.

Slip in the Slackware installation DVD into the CD tray, restart the system, and hit the **[F12]** key to start the installation process. The beauty of Slackware is that that you can